



CCCH9067 Man Up: Chinese Masculinities in the Making

Winning the Bread: From the Chinese Laborer to the Entrepreneur

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L4 Outcomes

- Explore China's historical favour of *wen* and how it is reminiscent of the “little fresh meat” phenomenon today
- Examine the popularisation of “little fresh meat” in China as a result of the rise of the female-oriented, transnational Boys' Love (BL) subculture
- Investigate the official and public responses to “little fresh meat” and the reasons behind them



Masculinity (also named manliness or manhood) is a set of characteristics, behaviors and roles associated with boys and men

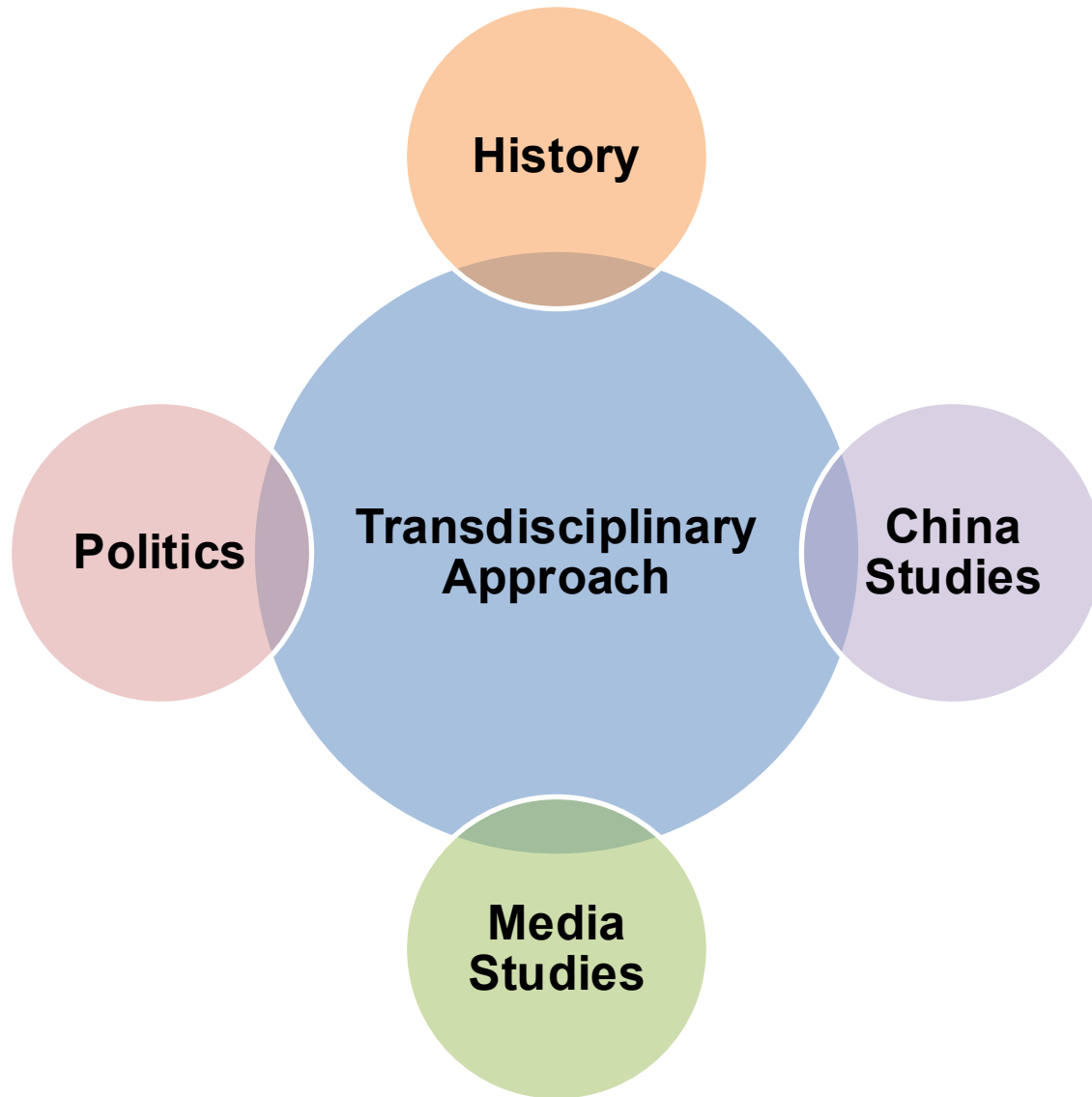
The notion of masculinity is not static. It changes across time, cultures, and situations

Learning Outcomes

- Analyze the historical role of different stakeholders in sustaining and challenging men's predominant position in China.
- Explain the political, social and cultural factors that shaped the ideals of Chinese masculinities at various historical junctures.
- Evaluate how China's twentieth-century reforms and revolutions shaped men's evolving image and experience.
- Reflect upon and critically assess the value of Chinese masculinity studies as an emerging field in the humanities.

Man Up examines China's history of reforms and revolutions through the lenses of **Chinese masculinity** and **intersectionality**. By investigating changes and continuities in China's history and contemporary state, we ask:

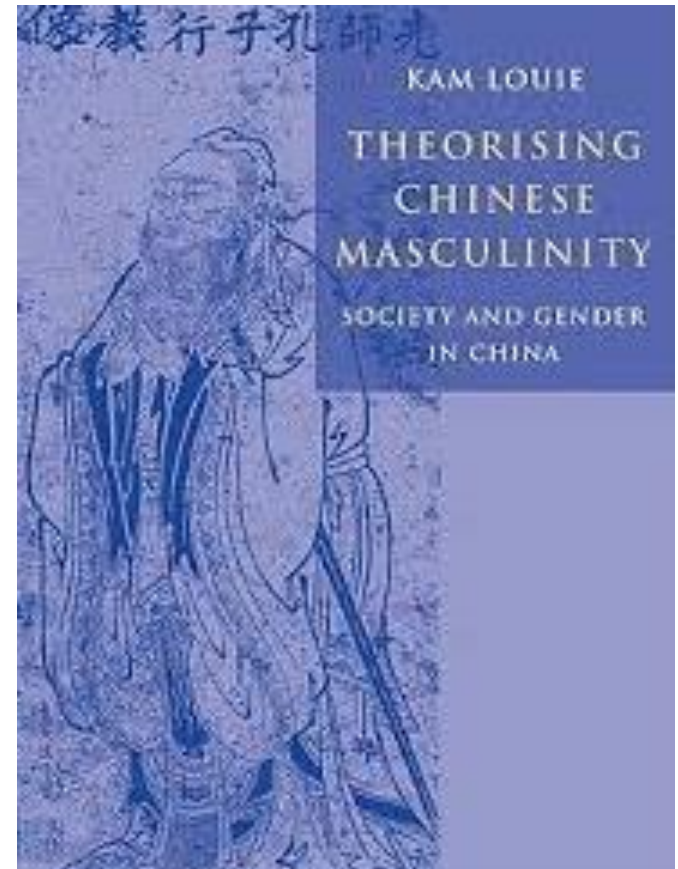
What do China's past and present tell us about its future directions? How have China's reforms, revolutions, and future plans put men on the agenda, and how have men responded?



Scholars have identified Asian masculinity as an alternative framework to Western masculinity

Kam Louie proposes that Chinese masculinity is characterized by a combination of *wen* 文 (literary skills and cultural attainment) and *wu* 武 (martial valour and physical strength)

Kam Louie, *Theorising Chinese Masculinity: Society and Gender in China* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2002).





Since the Tang dynasty (618–907), *wen* (the “soft” masculinity of the scholar) has occupied a central position in Chinese high culture, which values sophisticated tastes in art and literature

Talented scholars (*caizi* 才子) who excelled in the imperial examinations in the past, and those with literary talent in modern times, have often had more political influence than soldiers in Chinese societies that value educational achievements

Talented scholars also had great appeal to women (e.g. love stories between a talented scholar (*caizi* 才子) and a beautiful woman (*jiaren* 佳人), generating the genre of scholar-beauty romance (e.g. Jia Baoyu 賈寶玉 in *Dream of the Red Chamber* 紅樓夢, a Qing dynasty novel first printed in 1791)

Wang Yiyan, 'Mr Butterfly in *Defunct Capital*: “soft” masculinity and (mis)engendering China' in Kam Louie and Morris Low, *Asian Masculinities: The Meaning and Practice of Manhood in China and Japan* (London: Routledge, 2003).

The Second Sino-Japanese War (1937–45) and the Chinese Civil War (1945–49) challenged the “soft” masculinity of the scholar and made martial valour more attractive. The founding of the People’s Republic of China (PRC) in 1949 further reinforced the ideal of the physically strong soldier

For both women and men, the worker-peasant-soldier (工農兵) image became the standard of the new social order

Antonia Finnane, *Changing Clothes in China: Fashion, History, Nation* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2008).



01: Workers, Peasants and Soldiers (工農兵) in the early People's Republic of China (PRC)

02: Chinese Metrosexuals in a Globalised World

03: From Lying Flat (*tangping* 躺平) to Let It Rot (*bailan* 擺爛): A Crisis of Chinese Masculinity?



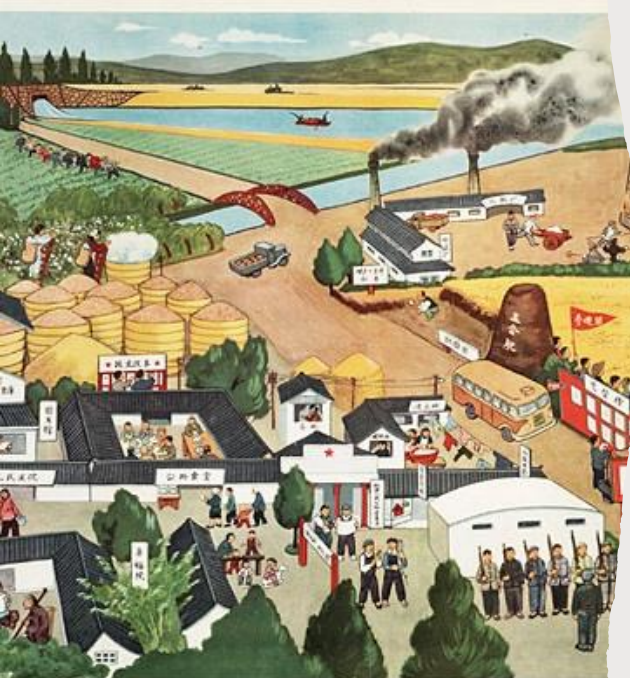
01: Workers, Peasants and Soldiers (工農兵)
in the early People's Republic of China (PRC)



Between 1958 and 1983, individuals – both women and men – were required to work and live in the People's Communes

The People's Communes were more than just collective farms. By redistributing arable land to the peasants, they became the core of local government and managed all economic and social activities

In theory, individuals in the People's Communes earned the same wages, all subject to the control of political leaders





In the People's Communes and across the PRC, workers, peasants and soldiers (工農兵) emerged as an idealized, collective identity

Workers, peasants and soldiers were considered the most radical proletarians in the socialist economy and pillars of the new society

Manfred R. Romich, 'The Chinese People's Communes and the Modernization of Agriculture,' *China Report* Vol. 17, Issue 6 (1981), 15-24.

Propaganda during the Cultural Revolution (1966–76) portrayed workers, peasants and soldiers in a positive light, contrasting them with landlords, rich peasants, counter-revolutionaries and rightists

In reality, workers, peasants and soldiers were largely a mythical category to serve larger political goals and demonstrate loyalty to Mao Zedong, the Party leader

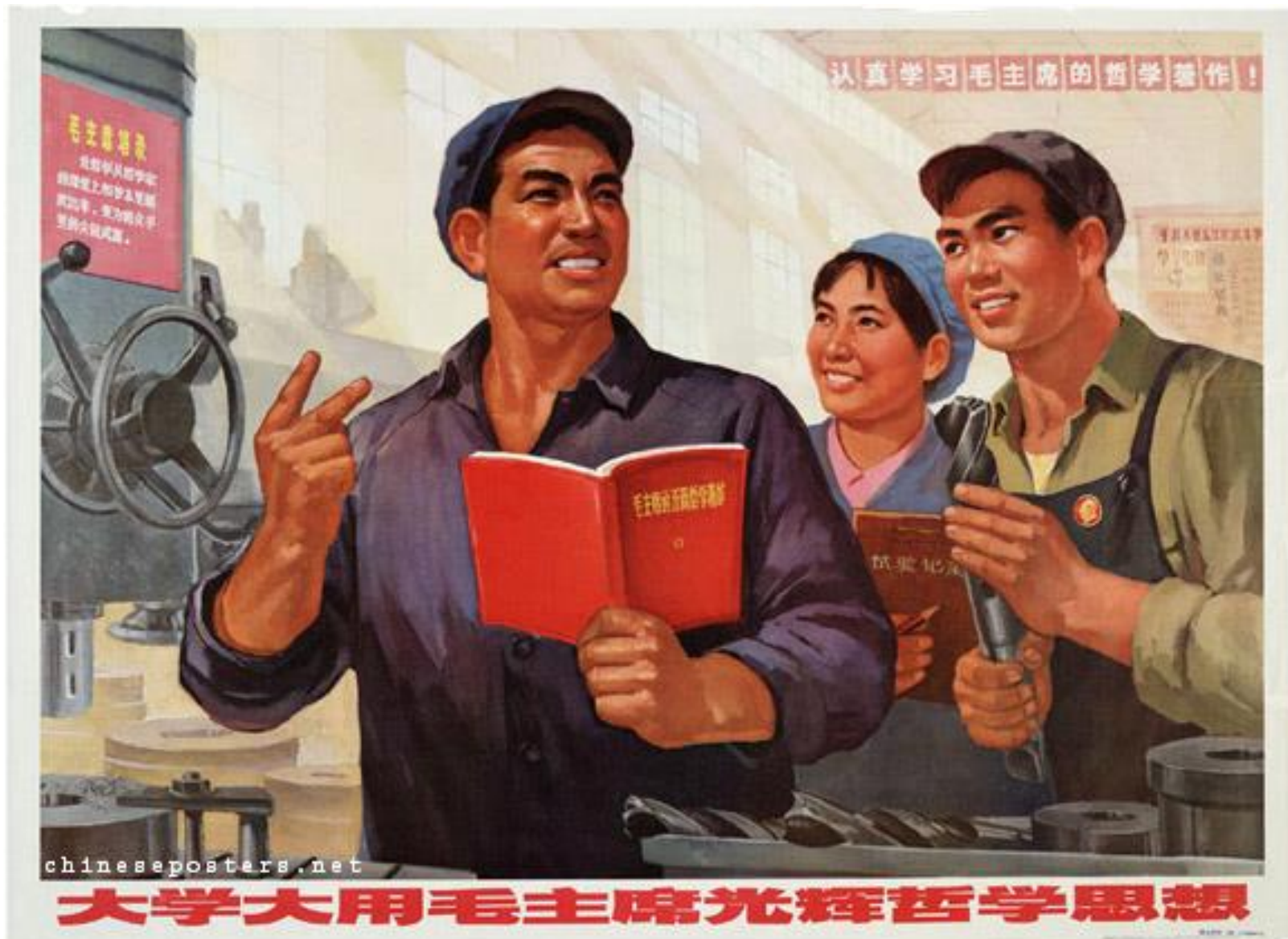
Manfred R. Romich, 'The Chinese People's Communes and the Modernization of Agriculture,' *China Report* Vol. 17, Issue 6 (1981), 15-24.



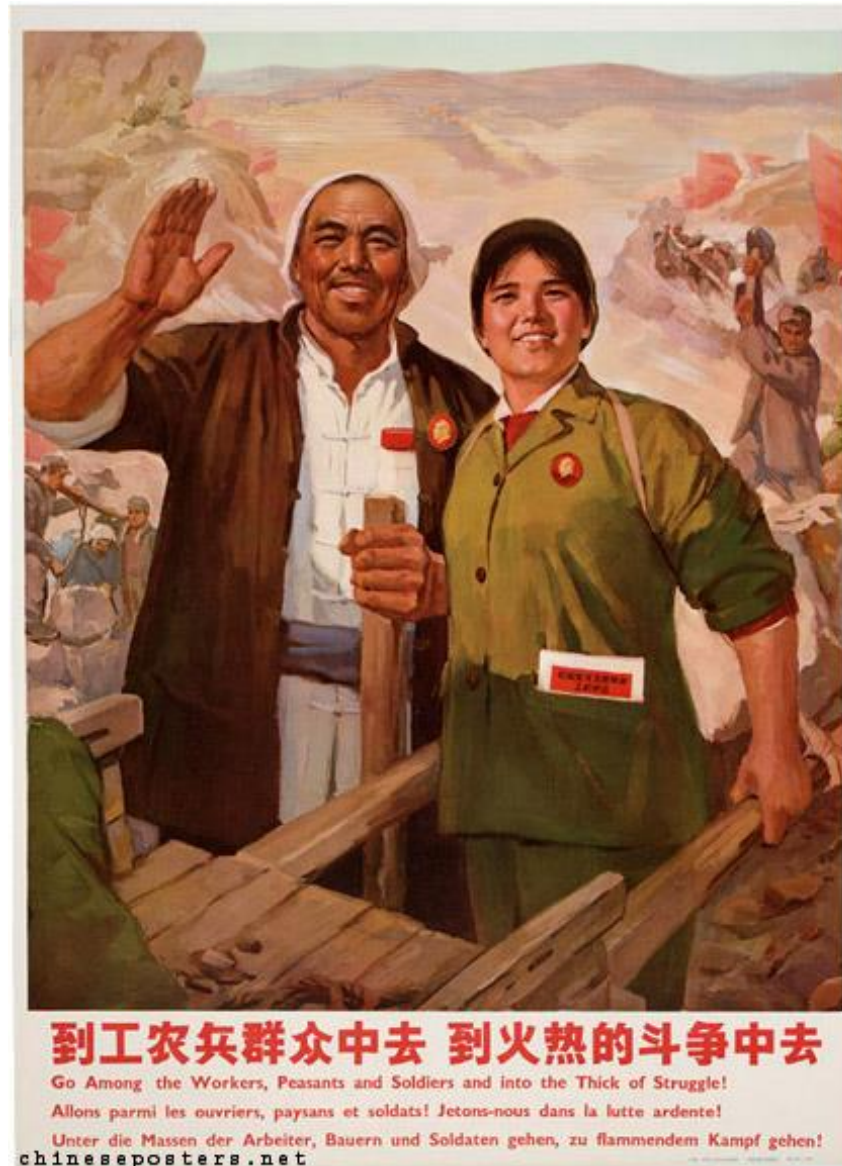
Greet the 1970s with the new victories of revolution and production, 1970



Prepare for war, prepare for famine, for the people, 1970. The poster portrays the worker-peasant-soldier preparing for the threat of an invasion by the Soviet Union or the United States



Use and study Chairman Mao's glorious philosophical thought in a big way, 1971. The poster describes Mao's writings being able to answer every question, including daily work in the factory



Go among the workers, peasants and soldiers and into the thick of struggle! 1970. An export poster to be distributed by Maoist groups in Europe and the United States



COMRADE DENG XIAO-PING IN HIS SOUTH INVESTIGATION TOUR TO SHENZHEN

邓小平同志南巡深圳

After the Cultural Revolution, as large-scale political movements gradually ceased in China, the collective identity of workers, peasants and soldiers (工農兵) fell out of favour

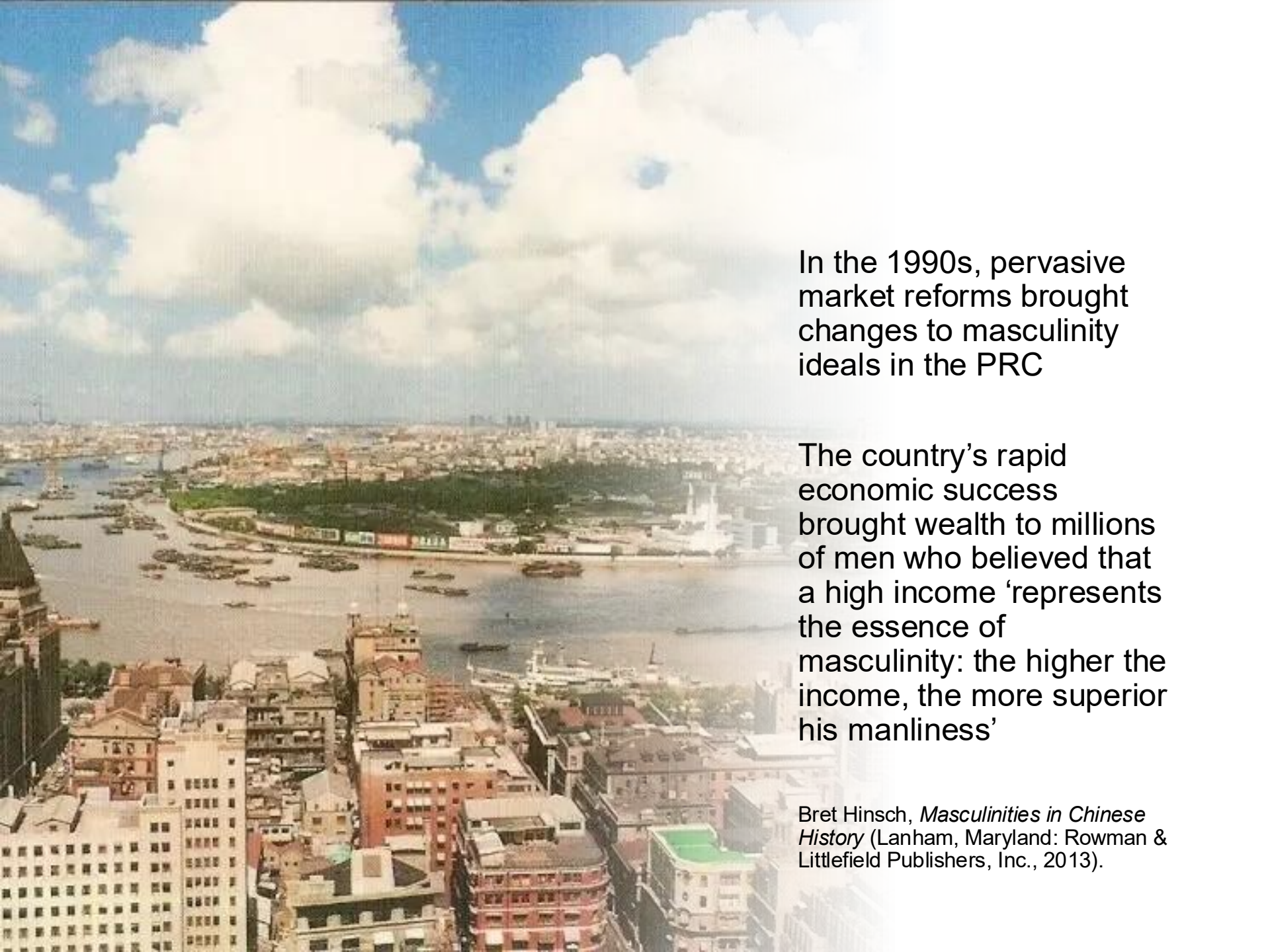
Starting from 1978, under Deng Xiaoping's "Open Door Policy", the PRC shifted from a closed, centralised planned economy to one that opened to foreign investment and global markets. The new focus on fostering economic growth also brought changes to masculinity ideals

Mentimeter exercise

Why did the collective identity of workers, peasants and soldiers (工農兵) lose its appeal after the Cultural Revolution?



02: Chinese Metrosexuals in a Globalised World



In the 1990s, pervasive market reforms brought changes to masculinity ideals in the PRC

The country's rapid economic success brought wealth to millions of men who believed that a high income 'represents the essence of masculinity: the higher the income, the more superior his manliness'

Bret Hinsch, *Masculinities in Chinese History* (Lanham, Maryland: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, Inc., 2013).



In urban China, a man proves his masculinity through a white-collar job, business acumen, financial assets and an appreciation for prestigious foreign clothing brands – all quintessential elements of the new Chinese ‘metrosexual’ in a globalised world

Song Geng and Derek Hird, *Men and Masculinities in Contemporary China* (Leiden: Brill, 2014).



Metrosexual is a term derived from the combination of 'metropolitan' and 'heterosexual'. It refers to a man who is meticulous about his appearance and spends significant time and money on it

A metrosexual can be gay, bisexual or heterosexual

The Chinese term for metrosexual is literally translated as *bailing linan* (白領麗男 white-collar beautiful man) or *dushilinan* (都市麗男 city beautiful man)

Kam Louie argues that the Chinese metrosexual still incorporates the competitive core of 'wen' (文 literary skills) within the wen-wu paradigm (文武 literary skills and martial arts skills)

Kam Louie, "Popular Culture and Masculinity Ideals in East Asia, with Special Reference to China," *The Journal of Asian Studies* 71, no. 4 (2012): 929–43.





BEFORE



AFTER

In Shenzhen, the home of tech giants like Tencent, men's growing spending power has allowed them to pay more attention to their appearance

In 2018 a Shenzhen-based fashion key opinion leader, Shenyefashi, initiated a 'Straight Guy Makeover' series, modelled after *Queer Eye*, which transforms untidy straight men into metrosexuals



Louie argues that the Chinese metrosexual typically enjoys global connections, is obsessed with displaying wealth, and engages in activities such as speaking English, drinking French wine, and communicating with others in cyberspace

This form of masculinity can only be attained by the moneyed classes – by individuals who can afford luxurious goods

The Chinese metrosexual is indicative of the geopolitical position that China occupies in the new millennium

Kam Louie, "Popular Culture and Masculinity Ideals in East Asia, with Special Reference to China," *The Journal of Asian Studies* 71, no. 4 (2012): 929–43.



03: From Lying Flat (*tangping* 躺平) to Let It Rot (*bailan* 擺爛): A Crisis of Chinese Masculinity?

Into the new millennium, China's economic miracle owes much to its unique geopolitical position and employees' extremely long working hours, especially in tech firms

The gruelling 996 culture – meaning 9 a.m. to 9 p.m., six days a week, contributing to a 72-hour workweek – is technically against the law, but is still commonly practiced in the workplace

躺平



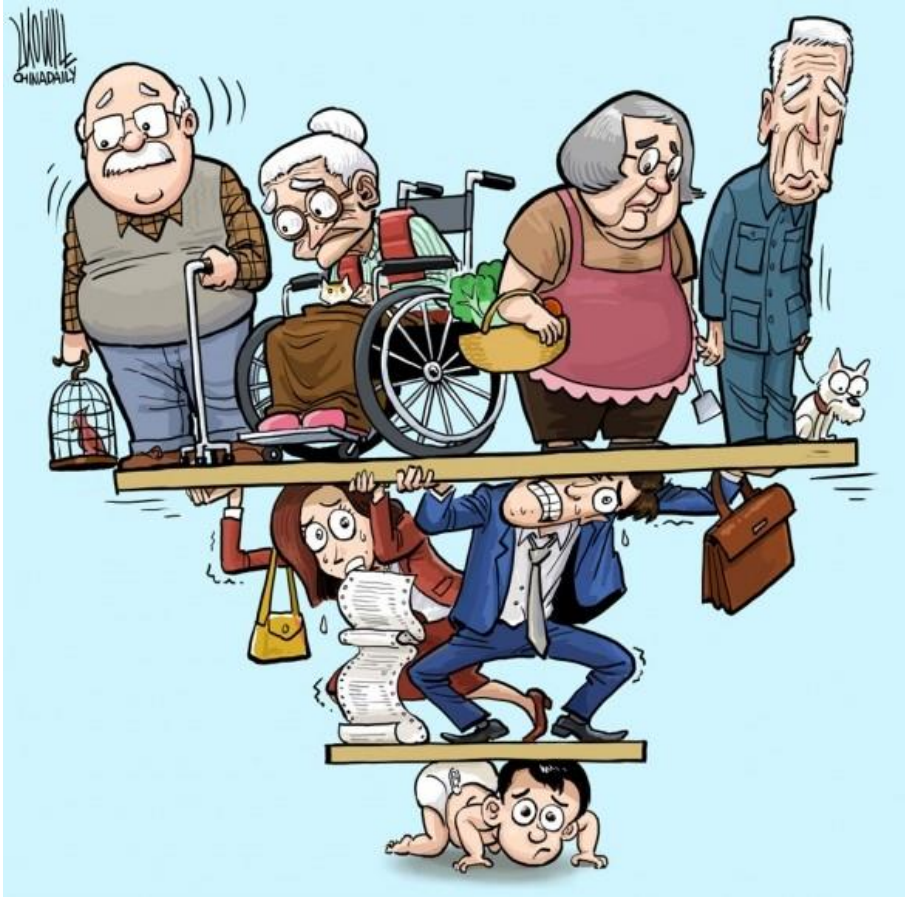
In 2021, the “lying flat” (*tangping* 躺平) movement began to take root among young Chinese citizens, as many felt under increasing pressure to work even harder and outperform their peers

“Lying flat” (*tangping* 躺平) means taking a break from relentless work



In 2022, online gaming communities introduced the term “Let It Rot” (*bailan* 擺爛), which means giving up, not even trying, or actively embracing a bad situation

Originally a basketball term, “Let It Rot” (*bailan* 擺爛) refers to individuals who voluntarily retreat in the face of a losing battle



Lying Flat (*tangping* 躺平) and Let It Rot (*bailan* 擺爛) are the result of a shrinking labour market in China, coupled with the pressures brought on by the COVID-19 pandemic, which has led to layoffs and increased workloads for those who remain employed

China's former one-child policy (1979–2015) has meant that many young men have grown up without siblings and will be solely responsible for caring for elderly parents and grandparents (the so-called 4-2-1 family structure)



Lecture 2 “Bare Branches” shows that prevailing patriarchal values put pressure on women to marry up, and on men to pay a bride price and buy a flat

Today, many young men in their 20s and 30s worry that they will never be able to achieve these things. Chinese social media sites offer solace to men by encouraging them to pursue a slower-paced life



In 2021, President Xi Jinping issued an explicit warning against ‘Lying Flat’:

“It is necessary to prevent the solidification of social strata, smooth the upward flow channels, create opportunities for more people to become rich, form a development environment where everyone participates, and avoid ‘involution’ and ‘lying flat’”.

要防止社会阶层固化，畅通向上流动通道，给更多人创造致富机会，形成人人参与的发展环境，避免“内卷”、“躺平”。

In *Man Up*, we ask to what extent Lying Flat (*tangping* 躺平) and Let It Rot (*bailan* 擺爛) represent a crisis of masculinity in China

Outcomes

- Explore how the mythical category of workers, peasants and soldiers was created to serve larger political goals in the early PRC
- Examine the emergence of Chinese metrosexuals as a result of China's rapid economic success and rising geopolitical importance in the new millennium
- Question to what extent Lying Flat (*tangping* 躺平) and/ or Let It Rot (*bailan* 擺爛) represent a crisis of masculinity in China

Reminder

- Lecture 6: Debating Gen Z Outlook on Chinese masculinities – prepare a few keywords or a one-line comment for discussion